

“This is the **only military command** in American history wherein **a woman, black or white, led the raid ...**”

SECRETARY OF WAR EDWIN M. STANTON ON THE COMBAHEE RIVER RAID

## **Humanitarian to the last**

A few weeks later, Tubman traveled with the 54th Massachusetts to its launching point at Battery Wagner, reportedly serving Colonel Robert Gould Shaw his last meal. For the rest of the war, she worked without pay for Union forces as they tightened the noose around Charleston, South Carolina, assisting with fugitive slaves, scouting deeper into Confederate territory, and advising Federal officers about the needs of the freedmen. Toward the end of the war she served as a volunteer nurse in Virginia, finally heading back to New York following Lee's surrender.

Tubman never enjoyed official status during the Civil War, even though her contributions to the Northern cause were well-known in Washington. She received no pay for all her sacrifices before or during the war, and it was not until 1899 that she received a pension. Tubman spent most of the meager sums she earned doing odd jobs to support her elderly parents and the formerly enslaved people she boarded at her home. Friends and admirers were outraged at the poverty she endured and periodically raised monies for her support. She also earned royalties from her biographies.

In Tubman's later years, she discovered a new cause: the women's suffrage movement. When asked by a white woman if she thought females should be able to vote, she replied, "I suffered enough to believe it." Advocates of women's suffrage Susan B. Anthony and Emily Howland counted Tubman as a colleague and friend. In 1903, she donated land she owned to create a home for